The Birth of Air India

Air India (initially known as Tata Airlines) was the upshot of the vision and passion of JRD, who was India's first licenced pilot, and a set of favourable circumstances. They combined with his nationalistic urge to fill the gap in the country's air transport facility and his keen acumen that sensed a business opportunity in accomplishing the national goal.

The underlying philosophy of the approach also became the guiding principle of the current Group Chairman N. Chandrasekaran, who declares with a flourish that the nation's and Tata's interests are no different. It became the lift under the wings of his determination to bring home the Maharaja.

JRD partnered with Nevill Vintcent, a South African aviator and former Royal Air Force pilot, to set up India's first commercial airline. It took three years of untiring efforts to get the British government's approval. The airline was started with an initial capital of Rs 200,000 on 15 October 1932, and JRD flew the first flight from Karachi to Bombay in a de Havilland Puss Moth, carrying 25 kg of mail.

Fourteen years later, Tata Airlines became a public company and was renamed Air-India Limited. It went international in 1948 and earned the encomium of Asia's first airline to connect the continent with Europe. It launched regular international services, with its first Bombay–London flight bearing its iconic mascot, the Maharaja.

A Heart-breaking Event

After 1949, the aviation landscape in India took a turn for the worse, with a 'ruinous scramble for route licenses' and 'interference by the executive'. The freedom of the Air Transport Licensing Board was 'subordinated to the wishes and directives of the [Aviation] Ministry'.

In 1953, in an ill-advised decision, the government nationalized all Indian airlines. It was a time when the airline finances in the country had skidded into a perilous state primarily because the government, without much thought, gave out licences for airlines 'far in excess of requirements' making the aviation business economically unsustainable, as JRD said in his farewell address to the shareholders of Air India Ltd after it was nationalized.